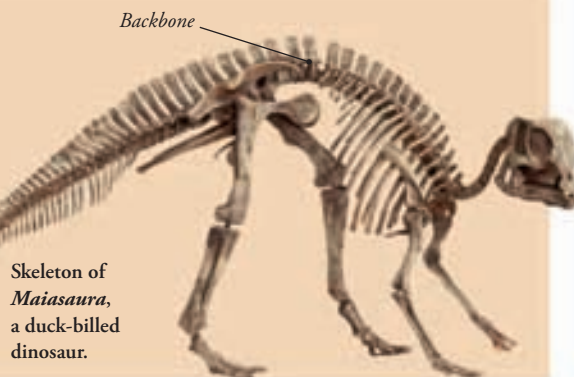
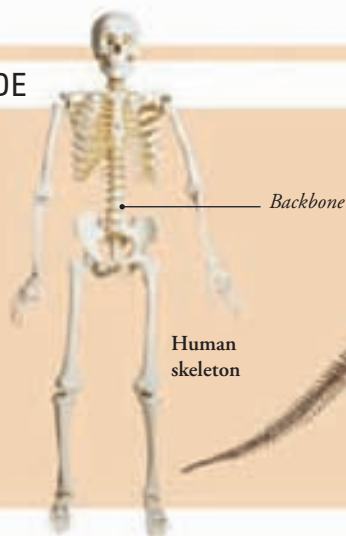




TAKE A LOOK—A PEEP INSIDE

Vertebrates have a backbone and internal bony skeleton. They also have a highly developed nervous system, and a larger brain for body size than invertebrates. Blood is pumped around the body by the heart, supplying the vertebrate's body with food and oxygen and removing waste products. They breathe using lungs.

► **BONE** is a lightweight, living organ, and it is found only in vertebrates. Because it is supplied with blood vessels, it can grow (unlike the hard casing of an invertebrate such as a crab, which has to be shed to allow growth).



Skeleto of *Maiasaura*, a duck-billed dinosaur.

REPTILES

Along with some amphibians, reptiles were the first vertebrates to live entirely on land. Their skin is dry and covered in scales to help retain water, a necessary adaptation, since many reptiles live in warm areas with limited access to water.



Parson's chameleon

► MILK SNAKE

Some species of reptile have to shed their skin as they grow. They do this between four and eight times a year.



▼ CAIMAN

Crocodilians, such as the caiman below, have thrived since they appeared with early dinosaurs, some 200 million years ago.



AMPHIBIANS

Modern amphibians have moist, soft skin, and most amphibians can absorb oxygen through this skin in addition to having lungs. They largely live on land but require damp conditions. Most have to return to water to lay eggs.



◀ **CHINESE GIANT SALAMANDER** (the world's largest living amphibian).

► FIRE SALAMANDER

This salamander will curl up underground in colder, winter months. Its bright color warns predators it is poisonous.



▼ POISON

DART FROG There are some 4,500 species of frog and toad, including about 120 species of poison dart frog.



FISH

Earth's first vertebrates—fish—now form more than half of all vertebrate species. Gills allow them to breathe underwater.



Spiny puffer fish

▼ **WHALE SHARK** This is the world's largest fish. Despite its size, it feeds on plankton—tiny organisms that drift in water.



▼ **STAYING TOGETHER** Many fish swim in schools, finding safety in numbers.

